Captain experience

Finalized decisions and immediate build order. Captain is not in production. This document locks the first restaurant release so the phone app is not redesigned again after the first sites go live. 3 October 2026.

> **Verdict**
>
> Approve the direction. Pairing and stale work are the real problems. The ordering shell stays. Three changes from the earlier review are now binding: kitchen notes ship in this release, old open tickets stay reachable, and optimistic quantity waits for a real service.

1. What changed from the earlier review

1. **Kitchen notes move into this release**
   A captain must be able to send Paneer Tikka, qty 2, note "No onion", and have that note travel on that line to the kitchen slip. The note belongs to the order line, not the order.
2. **Do not hide old open work**
   Default the floor and the KOT tab to current-service actionable work. Keep All, so a legitimate open table never disappears because the shift changed.
3. **Defer optimistic quantity**
   Quantity stays server-authoritative. Idempotent client operations, sent versus unsent qty, and void rules are already sensitive. Measure real Wi-Fi before making the stepper lie and then roll back.

2. Keep the shell

Do not turn this into a Captain redesign. The menu-first flow, teal tokens, bottom navigation, and gateway session model stay.

- No billing or settle from the phone.
- No food photos and no second visual system.
- No swipe-only gestures.
- No gateway TLS and no Capacitor in this release.
- No offline mutation queue.
- No optimistic plus and minus.
- Readable pairing words (BLUE-7K) are a fallback later, not the way captains pair.
- restoniti.local waits until after restaurant trials. The QR already solves discovery.

3. Menu: what the standard is, and what we will ship

Handheld waiter apps that stay fast (Indian captain apps and the better handheld POS products) use one column, a sticky search, category chips, a visible short code, a veg or non-veg mark, a large add control, and a note before the kitchen fire. Photo grids look richer and get slower once a menu passes a few dozen items. Captain already uses the right layout: a list, search, categories, and a 48px add control.

We will not replace the list with tiles. The unused tile CSS stays unused. These are the gaps versus that standard:

- Search by code already works. The menu filters on item name and SKU, and the field already says "Search name or code". The code is not shown on the row, so captains cannot see or learn it. Billing search shows the SKU. Captain will show it the same way, under the name, when the item has one.
- Veg, egg, and non-veg are words in the price line. Use the small diet mark captains already know, with the word kept for clarity.
- A line note is missing. That is the in-service gap, covered in section 6.
- When one item has two variants on the same ticket, the stepper can change the wrong line. The stepper must target the variant that is on that row.

That is the menu contract. After this release we do not reopen layout, photos, or a second search box.

4. Back: it must not close the app

The in-app chevron on a table does not close Captain. It returns to the floor and keeps the order in memory. There is no browser history stack, so the phone Back button is a different control. On Android that button can leave the page or close the browser. That is not acceptable for a shift.

This release maps phone Back onto the same stack as the chevron:

- A sheet is open (review, variant, void, area, category): Back closes that sheet only.
- Menu: Back returns to the floor. The table and unsent items stay. Resume brings them back.
- KOTs or Me: Back returns to the floor.
- Floor or login: Back stays inside Captain. It does not exit, and it does not sign the captain out.

Unsent items are not discarded by Back. Leaving a table is not a cancel. Sign out stays on Me, and it asks before it clears the session.

5. Pairing, without a new architecture

The gateway, 6-character code, and in-memory LAN session stay. The change is how a captain reaches them.

POS: Captain phones

- Replace the tiny header chip as the only pairing UI.
- Large pairing code, full URL, Copy URL, QR, and connected phones.
- QR encodes http://<lan-ip>:4747/?pair=CODE.
- Rotate stays available to a manager, and it does not pretend existing phones are still paired.

Phone: login

- Scanning or opening that URL fills the pairing code. The captain does not type the IP or the hex.
- Normal login shows restaurant name, last username, connection, and pairing. Password is the field they use every day.
- The pairing field appears only for a first phone, a changed code, or an invalid code.
- Normalize the code: trim, ignore case, ignore spaces.

Hard rule: paired is not connected

Me and login must not treat a saved string as a live link.

- Pairing: RestoNiti, Paired. This means a code is saved.
- Connection: Connected, Reconnecting, or POS unavailable. This means the gateway answered.
- After a POS restart: Pairing stays Paired. Connection becomes Reconnecting, then login if the session died.
- After the code is rotated or rejected: Pairing becomes Needs pairing, and the code field opens.

6. Kitchen notes

order_lines has no note column today. Add kitchen_note on the line, expose it on the order line used by Captain and the POS, and print it under that item on the KOT. Do not store the note on the order header.

- Set or edit the note while that line still has quantity waiting to send.
- The next Send to kitchen prints the note with the unsent quantity only.
- An already printed slip is never rewritten.
- When the line is fully sent, the note is read-only until more quantity is added.
- Adding more of the same item shows the previous note so they can keep it or change it for the next send.
- Desktop order rows show the same note, so the cashier and the kitchen are looking at one field.
- Empty note prints nothing. A note does not change price, tax, or KOT quantity.

7. Floor and KOT queue

What "current service" means

It does not mean "table created today". A table is in the default view when it still needs a send, or it had activity on the current business day: opened, items added, or a KOT sent. The business day is the same local day the POS already uses.

- Needs send: every table with unsent quantity, including an older table. This filter ignores age.
- Current service: the default. Actionable work for this business day, plus anything that still needs a send.
- All: every open table, including quiet tickets from previous days.
- Search by table name on the floor.
- Age color on tiles and KOT rows, using the age tone that already exists and is unused.
- Resume bar when a table session is still open and the captain is back on the floor.
- Opening one table disables that tile only, not the whole floor.

KOT tab

- Default filter is Send KOT, not a 12-day history.
- All remains one tap away.
- Each row shows the table, status, age, and the items, not only "KOT sent".
- Send to kitchen is the primary button on Review.
- Preview stays as a secondary action. It is not a required step.
- The button does not say Print KOT. Printing stays an implementation detail on the POS.

8. Errors

Each failure gets its own sentence. They must not collapse into one generic sign-in or network line.

- Wrong username or password.
- Account locked or inactive.
- Pairing code wrong, or the POS code was rotated.
- Could not reach the POS on this Wi-Fi.
- Kitchen printer did not print. The ticket state must say whether the send was saved.
- Someone else changed this table. Refresh and review quantity.

9. Build order

Build in this order so later pieces sit on finished contracts.

1. Line note in the database, order payload, and KOT print
Captain UI and the POS row both read kitchen_note. Do this before the send-button copy change, so the first kitchen slip is already complete.

2. POS Captain phones sheet and QR
URL plus ?pair=CODE. Copy URL. Connected phones. Login consumes the query and hides the code field.

3. Login and Me truth
Restaurant name, last username, separate Pairing and Connection. Needs pairing when the code is rejected.

4. Phone Back stack
Sheets, menu, tabs, and the floor. Back never exits and never drops unsent items.

5. Floor and KOT filters
Current service, Needs send, All, search, age color, Resume, single-tile busy state, items on KOT rows.

6. Send to kitchen

Primary action on Review. Preview secondary. Error copy for printer failure.

7. Menu finish

Show SKU, diet mark, note entry on the unsent line, variant stepper hits the correct line.

10. Next, after the first sites

- Human-readable pairing code as a spoken fallback. QR remains the primary pair.
- Me as a small help hub: this URL, device id, last sync, Add to Home Screen, Change pairing.
- Let a captain pin their areas, so 45 tables are not the daily view.
- Push table-layout changes over the existing event stream, or remove the unused listeners.
- Try a stable hostname only if restaurants still struggle after QR pairing.

11. Later

- Optimistic quantity, only if a real service shows the stepper waiting on the network.
- A short reconnect queue for the last add. Not a full offline POS.
- HTTPS or a native wrapper, only if install-to-home-screen becomes a real support problem.

12. Done when

A new captain, on restaurant Wi-Fi, with no one typing an IP:

- Scans the POS QR and signs in with name and password.
- Sees today’s work, not every ticket from the last two weeks.
- Finds a dish by name or by code, and can see the code on the row.
- Adds a line note and sends it to the kitchen in one primary tap from Review.
- Presses phone Back from the menu and lands on the floor, still signed in, with the table waiting on Resume.
- Can still open an older open table from All.
- After a POS restart, sees Paired and Reconnecting as two different facts, then signs in again with the saved username.

Source of these decisions: Captain SPA review, the live screenshots, Local Gateway pairing, order_lines (no note column yet), and the menu search that already matches SKU in MenuScreen.